WEIGHT 07

Liraglutide

Synthetic version of the gut hormone GLP-1 (97% the same sequence), with a fatty acid attached



CLASS Peptide

STUDIED FOR Weight, diabetes, heart risk

HUMAN EVIDENCE Large trials; FDA approved

US STATUS FDA approved (Saxenda, Victoza)

STUDIED FOR

- **Body weight** — HUMAN
- **Blood sugar** — HUMAN
- **Heart outcomes** — HUMAN

Victoza for weight is off-label. Victoza is approved for type 2 diabetes; Saxenda for weight. FDA records say Saxenda is to be discontinued in Jan 2027.

HOW IT WORKS IN THE BODY

Liraglutide ▶ GLP-1 receptor ▶ Appetite areas ▶ Fewer calories

- **Binds and activates** the GLP-1 receptor, like the body's own GLP-1 (label)
- **Resists breakdown** by the enzymes DPP-4 and NEP
- **Lowers weight** by lowering calorie intake, not by raising 24-hour energy use
- **Brain appetite areas** reached by the drug in animal studies

EVIDENCE & WHAT'S KNOWN

EVIDENCE

FDA APPROVED
LEVEL 5 OF 5

- SCALE: 3,731 adults, 56 weeks
- LEADER: 9,340 adults, median 3.8 years
- Generics approved since Dec 2024

NOT YET ESTABLISHED

- Weight benefit below 3 mg a day
- Thyroid C-cell tumors in people

QUICK PRACTICAL INFO

HALF-LIFE
13 hours (Saxenda label)

ROUTES STUDIED
Injection under the skin, once daily

PHARMACOKINETICS
Peak at 11 hours; resists DPP-4 and NEP breakdown

SOLD AS
Prescription injection (Saxenda, Victoza, generics)

MONITORED IN TRIALS
Weight, HbA1c; heart rate and kidney function per label

SPORT (WADA)
Not on the 2026 list

REGULATORY

FDA	Approved: Victoza 2010, Saxenda 2014, generics
FDA	On shortage list; compounded not FDA approved
EMA	Authorised (Victoza 2009, Saxenda 2015)
WADA	Not prohibited

REFERENCES

1. FDA, Saxenda prescribing information, Feb 2026
2. Pi-Sunyer et al., SCALE Obesity and Prediabetes, N Engl J Med, Jul 2015
3. WADA, 2026 Prohibited List

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